The Evolution and Investment Potential of the SpaceTech Sector

India Focus with Global Coverage

CONTEXT:

1. Introduction: The Rise of India's NewSpace Economy
2. Global Market Context
3. India Market Sizing & Growth Outlook

3a. Indian SpaceTech Ecosystem: Company & Funding Landscape

4. Policy Reforms & Government Support
5. Privatisation of the Space Sector: Significance & Challenges
6. Value Chain Structure & Market Segmentation
7. Competitive Landscape
8. M&A and IPO Activity
9. Business Models & Revenue Streams
10. Cost Structure of Space Tech Ventures
11. Key Growth Drivers (Indian SpaceTech Ecosystem)
12. Critical Barriers (Indian SpaceTech Ecosystem)
13. Sector Outlook & Investment Implications

1. Introduction: The Rise of India's NewSpace Economy

The space economy is undergoing a seismic shift, with independent firms driving unprecedented innovation and market expansion. In India, the space technology sector is rapidly evolving, supported by liberalised policies, increased funding and a surge in private entrepreneurial ventures.

India's space journey has historically been dominated by ISRO, but the New space era is rewriting this narrative. The opening of the space sector to private companies marks a paradigm shift, turning it into a collaborative ecosystem where public and private interests align to drive innovation. Startups now symbolise India's shift towards entrepreneurship and innovation in space, tapping into global markets with products and services that are competitive and often superior in cost-effectiveness.

A defining milestone came on **July 18, 2026**, when Skyroot Aerospace's **Vikram-1** became the first privately developed Indian rocket to reach orbit, placing India alongside the US and China.

This thesis examines the sector across global and Indian market sizing, the company and funding landscape, policy reforms, segmentation, competitive dynamics, M&A and IPO activity, business models, cost structure, growth drivers and barriers, and the resulting investment implications.

2. Global Market Context

Global Market Size

The space technology (spacetech) market size has grown strongly in recent years. It will grow from $498.44 billion in 2025 to $531.97 billion in 2026 at a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of 6.7%. The growth in the historic period can be attributed to increasing government and private investments in satellite and spacecraft development, technological advancements in spacecraft components and payload instruments, rising demand for earth observation and navigation services, growth in space debris tracking and management initiatives, early adoption of space tourism and commercial spaceflight services.

Metric	Value
Market size, 2024	USD 466.1 billion
Projected market size, 2026	USD 527.9 billion
Projected market size, 2030	USD 769.7 billion
CAGR, 2025–2030	9.3%
North America revenue share, 2024	46.0%

Global Company Landscape

The global space technology sector comprises **3,152 companies**, of which 1,103 are funded and 521 have secured Series A funding. To date, the sector has seen the creation of 24 unicorns. Named examples include

SpaceX, Planet, Skyroot, Paras Defence & Space Technologies and AST & Science. The United States has the largest number of companies, followed by India and the United Kingdom.

Country	Number of Space Tech Companies
United States	1,060
India	351
United Kingdom	209

2026 has seen the creation of 85 space tech companies so far, against an average of 169 new companies launched every year over the last 10 years.

3. India Market Sizing & Growth Outlook

Market Data-Book Estimate

India's space economy, currently estimated to be at $13 billion, is set to touch $40 billion by 2030, according to the recent India Spacetech-2026 report by early-stage venture capital firm, Arkam Ventures.

Parameter	Detail
Market revenue, 2023	USD 9,999.6 million
Market revenue, 2030	USD 20,989.8 million
Growth rate	11.2% CAGR (stated as 2024–2030 in the market highlights and 2023–2030 in the data book)
Largest segment	Space vehicles (largest revenue-generating type in 2023)
Fastest-growing segment	Deep-space communication
Segmentation	Space vehicles, deep-space communication, in-space propulsion
Historical data / base year	2018–2022 / 2023
Forecast period	2024–2030
Quantitative units	Revenue in USD million

- **Share of global market:** India accounted for 2.6% of the global space technology market by revenue in 2023.
- **Global and regional leaders:** the U.S. is expected to lead the global market by revenue in 2030, while China is projected to lead the Asia Pacific regional market.
- **Regional growth:** India is the fastest-growing regional market in Asia Pacific and is projected to reach USD 20,989.8 million by 2030.

3a. Indian SpaceTech Ecosystem: Company & Funding Landscape

Ecosystem Snapshot

351 space tech startups, of which 109 are funded, 28 have secured Series A+ funding and 1 has achieved unicorn status.

Metric	Value
Companies	351
Funded companies / startups	109
Series A+ funded	28
Unicorns	1
New companies in 2026 to date	15
Average new companies per year (10 years)	26

Top companies include Skyroot, Paras Defence & Space Technologies, Dhruva Space, Pixxel and GalaxEye. Several startups have been founded by alumni of IIT Madras, BITS Pilani and IIT Bombay.

Private Sector Involvement and Capital

- As many as 100 spacetech startups recently registered with the Indian Space Research Organisation, and around 200 spacetech startups are contributing to a rapidly expanding ecosystem.
- NewSpace India Limited (NSIL) and the Indian Space Association (ISpA) are among the key organisations enabling public-private synergy and paving the way for broader private participation.
- Private equity involvement is increasing: India's spacetech startups raised **USD 233 million across 30+ deals between 2014 and May 2023**.

Funding Concentration

Two companies anchor the Indian spacetech market, together accounting for the largest share of disclosed funding. Each takes a different route into the same opportunity: launch and Earth observation.

Company	Funding	Focus
Skyroot Aerospace	~$150 million (Series C)	Orbital launch vehicles
Pixxel	~$96 million (Series B)	Hyperspectral Earth observation

Three cities account for the vast majority of India spacetech funding. Bengaluru leads by a significant margin, driven by ISRO's satellite centre, IISc and a deep-tech talent base.

City	Reported funding
Bengaluru	Leads by a significant margin
Hyderabad	~$205 million
Chennai	~$80 million

4. Policy Reforms & Government Support

India's space sector has undergone major institutional and policy reforms that have opened it to private participation. The government has also signalled a growing focus on the space economy and on private sector-driven research and innovation at commercial scale.

Reform / Measure	Description
NewSpace India Limited (2019)	Set up as ISRO's commercial arm to transfer technology, manufacture satellites and launch vehicles through industry, and provide commercial satellite services.
IN-SPACe (2020)	Indian National Space Promotion and Authorisation Centre; acts as a single-window regulator and facilitator for private companies, authorising and promoting their participation in space activities.
IN-SPACe schemes	Seed Fund Scheme, Pricing Support Policy, Mentorship Support, Design Lab for NGEs, Skill Development in Space Sector, ISRO facility utilisation support, and technology transfer to non-governmental entities (NGEs).
₹1,000 crore VC Fund	Venture capital fund under IN-SPACe, announced in the Finance budget, aiming to accelerate private participation in the space sector.
₹500 crore Technology Adoption Fund	Introduced by IN-SPACe (TAF) to support private participation in the sector.
0% GST regime	Set by the GST Council at its 50th meeting to foster emerging startups in the spacetech sector.
SpaceTech Innovation Network (SpIN)	A one-of-its-kind public-private collaboration for start-ups and SMEs in the space industry.

Liberalised FDI Policy for Space

The revised FDI policy permits automatic foreign investment up to the following limits:

Activity	Automatic FDI limit
Satellite manufacturing and operations	Up to 74%
Launch vehicles and spaceports	Up to 49%
Manufacturing of satellite components and subsystems	Up to 100%

5. Privatisation of the Space Sector: Significance & Challenges

Significance

- **Cost efficiency:** private companies operate with a profit motive, which drives them to reduce costs in space missions and satellite launches.
- **Competition:** privatisation introduces competition into the space industry, which can drive both efficiency and innovation.
- **Commercialisation of applications:** private players facilitate the commercialisation of space applications and services in agriculture, disaster management, urban planning, navigation and communication, among other sectors.

- **Autonomy:** private companies have a greater degree of autonomy in decision-making, which enables them to take up new projects.
- **Economic and strategic benefits:** it helps generate employment, enables modern technology absorption and makes the sector self-reliant.

Challenges

- **Capital intensity and concentration:** space technology is expensive and needs heavy investment, which is available only to selected rich corporates and can lead to monopolisation of the sector.
- **Specialised expertise:** building and operating space technology and infrastructure requires specialised technical expertise and resources.
- **Intellectual property:** protecting intellectual property rights (IPR) is crucial for incentivising innovation and investment in the space sector.
- **Global competition:** Indian private companies face stiff competition in the international market from established players such as SpaceX and Blue Origin.

6. Value Chain Structure & Market Segmentation

Value Chain Structure

The space market is organised into upstream, downstream and auxiliary segments. In addition, enablers such as contract manufacturers, component suppliers and testing facilities play a crucial role in supporting the ecosystem's growth.

Segment	Scope
Upstream	All activities, products and infrastructure ensuring the development, testing, launching, operations and monitoring (including space situational awareness) of space assets. Includes emerging in-situ areas such as space tourism, space-based manufacturing and space mining, as well as ground stations and space-asset monitoring, which are typically classified under midstream.
Downstream	Primarily sub-segmented into Earth observation (EO), satellite communication (SATCOM) and positioning, navigation & timing (PNT). Covers all applications, services and devices relying on satellites to create business value, including dual-purpose services that cater to strategic requirements.
Auxiliary	Activities, products and services derived from space technology in other sectors, such as manufacturing and health. Also includes space insurance and awareness, education and training.

Market Segmentation Framework

The SpaceTech market spans the full value chain from **launch and satellite infrastructure to in-space services, ground infrastructure, and downstream data and analytics**. To assess the market comprehensively, it can be viewed through two complementary lenses: **ecosystem segments**, which

describe where companies participate in the value chain, and **commercial market dimensions**, which describe how solutions are deployed, purchased and monetised.

1. SpaceTech Ecosystem Segmentation

Segment	Role in the ecosystem
Launch Providers	Build and operate launch vehicles that transport satellites, spacecraft and other payloads into orbit.
Satellite Operators & Services	Build, deploy and operate satellites and generate revenue from satellite-enabled services.
Defense & National Security	Develop satellites, sensors, communications systems and space-based infrastructure for national security and intelligence applications.
Space Stations & Habitats	Develop commercial space stations, habitats and infrastructure for human activity in orbit.
In-Space Services & Manufacturing	Provide satellite servicing, orbital transportation, in-space manufacturing and other activities conducted beyond Earth.
Satellite & Component Manufacturing	Manufacture spacecraft, satellite buses, payloads, propulsion systems, avionics and other critical components.
Ground Segment & Communications	Provide terrestrial infrastructure, ground stations, signal processing and communications systems connecting space assets with users.
Earth Observation & Geospatial Analytics	Convert satellite observations into information, intelligence and decision-support products for commercial, governmental and defence users.
Propulsion & In-Space Transportation	Provide propulsion systems and orbital transportation solutions for satellite manoeuvring, deployment and last-mile movement in space.
Emerging & Frontier	Develop new space-based markets and business models, including orbital computing, advanced sensing, autonomous servicing and in-space infrastructure.

This ecosystem is increasingly shifting from a **hardware-led model toward integrated infrastructure, services and data-driven applications**. While launch vehicles, satellites and components remain essential

2. Commercial Market Segmentation

Dimension	Sub-segments
Solution Type	Launch Services; Satellite Platforms and Payloads; Ground Systems; Space Data and Analytics; In-Space Infrastructure
Deployment Model	Dedicated Mission; Rideshare Mission; Hosted Payload; Constellation Deployment; Managed Data Service
End-Use Industry	Defense and Security; Telecommunications; Agriculture and Natural Resources; Infrastructure and Urban Development; Climate and Disaster Management
Customer Type	Government Space Agencies; Defense and Intelligence Organizations; Commercial Satellite Operators; Industrial and Infrastructure Corporates; Research and Academic Institutions
Application	Earth Observation; Satellite Communications; Navigation and Timing; Space Situational Awareness; Scientific Exploration
Pricing Model	Mission Contract; Capacity Lease; Data Subscription; Analytics as a Service; Equipment Sale and Maintenance

Solution Type

Solution Type remains the dominant analytical dimension because revenue originates from distinct hardware, mission and service pools. Satellite platforms and payloads form the largest established sub-segment, supported by government procurement and commercial constellation programmes. Space Data and Analytics is shifting the mix toward recurring revenue, while launch and in-space infrastructure require higher capital and longer qualification cycles.

Application

Application is the fastest-growing dimension as customers increasingly procure outcomes rather than spacecraft hardware alone. Earth Observation leads commercial adoption across agriculture, defense, climate monitoring, infrastructure and natural resources. Space Situational Awareness is expected to deliver the fastest specialised expansion because larger constellations and orbital congestion increase demand for tracking, collision assessment, mission planning and sovereign space-domain intelligence.

7. Competitive Landscape

7a. India: Startups to Watch

Rank	Startup	Core category	Funding / execution signal
1	Skyroot Aerospace	Small-satellite launch vehicles and dedicated orbital missions	$60M reported May 2026 round; Vikram-1 reached orbit in July 2026
2	Pixxel	Hyperspectral Earth observation, satellites and analytics	$95M total publicly disclosed after its $24M Series B extension
3	Digantara	Space situational awareness, surveillance and data infrastructure	$50M disclosed round in December 2025
4	Agnikul Cosmos	Customisable small launch vehicles and additive-manufactured engines	$17M reported in 2025 at a reported $500M valuation
5	Dhruva Space	Satellite platforms, deployers, ground stations and mission services	₹275 crore pre-Series B financing stated by the company, split between equity and debt
6	SatSure	Earth-observation data, AI and operational decision support	$15M Series A in 2023, comprising equity capital and venture debt
7	Bellatrix Aerospace	Satellite propulsion and orbital-transfer vehicles	$8M Series A publicly disclosed in 2022
8	GalaxEye	Multi-sensor Earth observation, SAR and optical intelligence	$10M Series A; POEM technology demonstration completed
9	Manastu Space	Green propulsion, refuelling, de-orbiting and mission-life extension	$3M reported funding round in 2025
10	TakeMe2Space	Orbital computing, satellite platforms and AI processing	$5M Series A reported in early 2026

7b. Global: Landscape by Category

Globally, the competitive landscape spans launch, satellite operations, defense, stations, in-space services, manufacturing, ground segment, Earth observation, propulsion and frontier ventures.

Selected Global Players

Company	Category	Highlights
SpaceX	Launch	165 Falcon 9 missions in 2025; operates the world's largest satellite constellation (Starlink, about 11,000 active satellites in September 2026); developing Starship. Listed on Nasdaq as SPCX on June 12, 2026, in what the source describes as the largest IPO in history.
Rocket Lab	Launch	Electron launcher; developing the Neutron medium-lift rocket; end-to-end offering spanning launch, spacecraft buses, components and mission operations; listed as RKLB.
Blue Origin	Launch	New Glenn maiden flight in early 2025; New Shepard suborbital vehicle; supplies BE-4 engines to ULA's Vulcan Centaur; building the Orbital Reef station and an Artemis lunar lander.
Relativity Space	Launch	Terran R medium-lift vehicle; 85%+ of the rocket printed on proprietary metal 3D printers; backed by over $1.3 billion in funding.
Arianespace / ArianeGroup	Launch	Ariane 6 completed its maiden flight in 2024; also operates the Vega-C small launcher; critical for European launch autonomy.
Planet Labs	Satellite operator	200+ Dove, SkySat and Tanager satellites imaging the entire land surface of Earth daily.
AST SpaceMobile	Satellite operator	Building a space-based cellular broadband network for unmodified smartphones; BlueWalker 3 test satellite demonstrated the concept. If successful, it could connect 5+ billion existing phones.
Iridium Communications	Satellite operator	66-satellite LEO constellation providing global coverage, including the poles.
Viasat	Satellite operator	Hybrid GEO-LEO network following the Inmarsat acquisition; ViaSat-3 satellites each provide 1+ Tbps of throughput.
Lockheed Martin	Defense	Largest defense contractor by revenue; builds GPS III and SBIRS satellites and the Orion crew capsule; Space division generates $12+ billion annually.
Axiom Space	Space station	Building commercial modules to attach to the ISS; NASA's partner for commercial LEO station development; valued at $5+ billion.
Vast	Space station	Developing Haven-1 and Haven-2; raised $400M+ in 2025 and secured a SpaceX Starship launch for Haven-2.
Sierra Space	Space station	Dream Chaser spaceplane and LIFE inflatable habitat modules; raised a $1.5 billion round in 2025.
Varda Space Industries	In-space services	In-space pharmaceutical manufacturing; its first re-entry capsule returned successfully in 2024.

Company	Category	Highlights
Amazon Kuiper (Amazon Leo)	Ground segment & comms	$10+ billion investment in a 3,236-satellite LEO broadband constellation; the source describes it as the only credible competitor to Starlink at scale.
Umbra	Earth observation	SAR constellation providing all-weather, day-and-night imaging at 16cm resolution.

8. M&A and IPO Activity

Acquisitions

M&A activity in the Indian space tech sector remains limited. One acquisition was recorded in 2026 (through April 2026) and one in 2025; the yearly trend also shows one acquisition in 2022 and none in 2017–2021 or 2023–2024.

Company	Acquisition type	Date	Acquirer
Aidin Technologies	Business acquisition	Apr 30, 2026	Nippo
Vellon Space	Business acquisition	Apr 30, 2025	Helogen
Prakshep	Business acquisition	Jun 02, 2022	Arya.ag

2026*	2025	2024	2023	2022	2017–2021
1	1	–	–	1	–

*Number of acquisitions by year. *2026 data is through April 2026.*

IPOs

One IPO was recorded in the Indian space tech sector in 2024 (through July 2024). The recent and notable listings are:

Company	IPO date	Exchange
Avantel	Jul 31, 2024	National Stock Exchange (NSE)
Paras Defence & Space Technologies	Oct 01, 2021	Bombay Stock Exchange (BSE), National Stock Exchange (NSE)
Mtar	Mar 15, 2021	Bombay Stock Exchange (BSE), National Stock Exchange (NSE)
AMPL	Nov 01, 2004	National Stock Exchange (NSE)
Nelco	May 28, 2003	National Stock Exchange (NSE)

9. Business Models & Revenue Streams

The segmentation framework identifies five pricing models across the sector: mission contracts, capacity leases, data subscriptions, analytics as a service, and equipment sale and maintenance. Space Data and Analytics is shifting the revenue mix toward recurring revenue, while launch and in-space infrastructure

require higher capital and longer qualification cycles. Spire Global's space-as-a-service model, which allows customers to deploy custom payloads on its satellite bus, is one example of a service-led approach.

Illustrative Revenue Model

The table below shows how a vertically integrated operator combines recurring, product, contract-based and long-term growth revenue streams.

Revenue stream	How it makes money	Revenue type	Why it matters
Subscriptions	Monthly internet plans for homes, businesses, ships, aircraft and remote users	Recurring	Supports more predictable cash flow
Hardware	User terminals, kits and enterprise equipment	Product sales	Helps connect new customers
Launch services	Sending satellites, cargo, crews and payloads into orbit	Contract-based	Core aerospace revenue
Government contracts	NASA, national security and public-sector missions	Contract-based	Adds scale and credibility
Defence and secure communications	Military satellite services and related infrastructure	Strategic contracts	High-value but politically sensitive
Future projects	Starship, lunar missions, Mars ambitions and direct-to-cell services	Long-term growth	Supports valuation expectations

10. Cost Structure of Space Tech Ventures

Entering the space technology sector requires significant capital expenditure (CapEx) alongside predictable operational expenditure (OpEx). The primary cost drivers for launching and scaling a space tech enterprise in India fall into three groups.

1. Research, Development and Prototyping

Before launching any hardware into orbit, extensive R&D is mandatory, including computer-aided engineering (CAE) simulations, thermal vacuum testing, vibration testing and avionics development.

- **Software and simulation tools:** licensing enterprise-grade orbital mechanics and CAD software varies significantly with seat counts and often forms a core initial digital CapEx.
- **Component sourcing and prototyping:** radiation-hardened microchips, sensors and structural alloys account for a major share of early-stage prototyping costs. Local sourcing initiatives in India have substantially reduced these material expenses compared with Western markets.

2. Infrastructure and Cleanroom Facilities

Manufacturing satellites or launch vehicle components requires ISO-certified cleanrooms and specialised testing rigs.

- **Cleanroom construction and maintenance:** setting up a Class 10,000 or Class 100,000 cleanroom involves specialised HVAC, filtration and anti-static flooring systems.
- **Testing infrastructure:** building an in-house thermal-vacuum chamber or acoustic test facility can be cost-prohibitive for early-stage ventures, so startups frequently leverage shared testing

infrastructure at academic institutions or specialised government testing centres, keeping upfront costs manageable.

3. Launch and Regulatory Compliance Costs

Securing a slot on a launch vehicle, such as ISRO's Small Satellite Launch Vehicle (SSLV) or Polar Satellite Launch Vehicle (PSLV), involves direct payload integration fees, insurance and regulatory authorisation fees managed through IN-SPACe.

11. Key Growth Drivers (Indian SpaceTech Ecosystem)

- **Liberalised policy and regulatory architecture:** IN-SPACe as a single-window regulator, NSIL as ISRO's commercial arm and a liberalised FDI policy (up to 74%, 49% and 100% automatic FDI across segments) have opened the sector to private participation.
- **Dedicated public capital and fiscal support:** a ₹1,000 crore VC fund, a ₹500 crore Technology Adoption Fund and a 0% GST regime for spacetech startups.
- **Expanding private entrepreneurship and rising capital inflow:** hundreds of startups across the value chain, supported by institutional enablers such as NSIL, ISpA and SpIN.
- **Demonstrated execution:** Vikram-1 reached orbit in July 2026, the first privately developed Indian rocket to do so.
- **Downstream demand:** the downstream segment accounts for two-thirds of industry revenue, and space-based communication is positioned to narrow the digital divide in India.
- **Outcome-based procurement:** customers increasingly procure outcomes rather than spacecraft hardware alone, favouring data, analytics and application-led business models.

12. Critical Barriers (Indian SpaceTech Ecosystem)

- **Capital intensity and concentration risk:** space technology needs heavy investment, which can lead to monopolisation of the sector by a few wealthy corporates.
- **Specialised expertise:** building and operating space technology and infrastructure requires specialised technical expertise and resources.
- **Intellectual property protection:** IPR protection is crucial for incentivising innovation and investment.
- **Global competition:** Indian private players face stiff competition from established international players such as SpaceX and Blue Origin.
- **Long qualification cycles:** launch and in-space infrastructure require higher capital and longer qualification cycles.
- **Execution and reliability risk:** the business test for launch players is whether missions can be delivered repeatedly at an attractive price, and for other players whether announced missions are actually achieved and delivered against order books.
- **Funding concentration:** disclosed funding is concentrated in two companies (Skyroot and Pixxel) and three cities (Bengaluru, Hyderabad and Chennai).
- **Limited exit track record:** only three acquisitions and a small number of listings are recorded in the sector to date.

13. Sector Outlook & Investment Implications

The Indian spacetech sector is at an inflection point. Institutional reforms, a liberalised FDI regime and dedicated public capital have opened the sector to private participation, and the orbital success of Vikram-1 in July 2026 provides a first proof point of private launch capability.

Value creation is nonetheless uneven across segments. Revenue originates from distinct hardware, mission and service pools: Space Data and Analytics is shifting the mix toward recurring revenue, and customers increasingly procure outcomes rather than hardware. Earth Observation leads commercial adoption, while Space Situational Awareness is expected to deliver the fastest specialised expansion. Launch and in-space infrastructure, by contrast, require higher capital and longer qualification cycles. The downstream segment already accounts for two-thirds of industry revenue.

Risks remain material. Funding is concentrated in a small number of companies and cities, global competitors operate at far greater scale, and the record of exits is thin. Investors should distinguish carefully between announced and achieved milestones, between equity, debt, grants and order-book value, and between component innovation and a complete commercial service.

Key Investment Considerations, 2026–29

- **Launch:** cadence and reliability of follow-on flights, production scale, customer manifests and the ability to deliver dedicated missions repeatedly at an attractive price (Skyroot Aerospace, Agnikul Cosmos).
- **Earth observation and data:** constellation deployment, revisit performance, data quality and recurring contracts, with data products that become workflow tools rather than visualisation layers (Pixxel, SatSure, GalaxEye).
- **Space situational awareness and defence:** deployment of sensors, sovereign and defence contracts and conversion of observations into decision-ready workflows (Digantara).
- **Propulsion and in-space services:** flight heritage, qualification with satellite platforms and customer trust in critical manoeuvres (Bellatrix Aerospace, Manastu Space).
- **Platforms and ground segment:** manufacturing expansion and delivery against the order book (Dhruva Space).
- **Orbital computing:** whether edge-processing economics remain compelling once launch, hardware and operations are included (TakeMe2Space).

Overall, companies that combine demonstrated execution with recurring or contracted revenue and credible government, defence or enterprise customers appear best placed to capture long-term value as India's space economy scales.

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